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The Visions of the Utopian Socialists

It is not difficult to understand why Malthus and Ricardo should have conceived of the world in gloomy terms. England in the 1820's was a gloomy place to live: it had emerged triumphant from a long struggle on the Continent, but now it seemed locked in an even worse struggle at home. For it was obvious to anyone who cared to look that the burgeoning factory system was piling up a social bill of dreadful proportions and that the day of reckoning on that bill could not be deferred forever.

Indeed, a recital of the conditions that prevailed in those early days of factory labor is so horrendous that it makes a modern reader's hair stand on end. In 1828, *The Lion*, a radical magazine of the times, published the incredible history of Robert Blincoe, one of eighty pauper-children sent off to a factory at Lowdham. The boys and girls—they were all about ten years old—were whipped day and night, not only for the slightest fault, but to stimulate their flagging industry. And compared with a factory at Litton where Blincoe was subsequently transferred, conditions at Lowdham were rather humane. At Litton the children scrambled with the pigs for the slops in a trough; they were kicked and punched and sexually abused; and their employer, one Ellice Needham, had the chilling habit of pinching the childrens

ears until his nails met through the flesh. The foreman of the plant was even worse. He hung Blincoe up by his wrists over a machine so that his knees were bent and then he piled heavy weights on his shoulders. He and his co-workers were almost naked in the cold of winter and (seemingly as a purely gratuitous sadistic flourish) their teeth were filed down!

Without a doubt such frightful brutality was the exception rather than the rule; indeed we suspect a little of the reformers' zeal has embellished the account. But with full discount for exaggeration, the story was nonetheless all too illustrative of a social climate in which practices of the most callous inhumanity were accepted as the natural order of events and even more important, as nobody's business. A sixteen-hour working day was not uncommon, with the working force tramping to the mills at six in the morning and trudging home at ten at night. And as a crowning indignity, many factory operators did not permit their workpeople to carry their own watches, and the single monitory factory clock showed a strange tendency to accelerate during the scant few minutes allowed for meals. The richest and most far-sighted of the industrialists may have deplored such excesses, but their factory managers or hard-pressed competitors seem to have regarded them with an indifferent eye.

And the horrors of working conditions were not the only cause for unrest. Machinery was now the rage, and machinery meant the displacement of laboring hands by uncomplaining steel. As early as 1779 a mob of eight thousand workers had attacked a mill and burned it to the ground in unreasoning defiance of its cold implacable mechanical efficiency, and by 1811 such protests against technology were sweeping England. Wrecked mills dotted the countryside and in their wake the word went about that "Ned Ludd had passed." The rumor was that a King Ludd or a General Ludd was directing the activities of the mob. It was not true, of course. The Luddites, as they were called, were fired by a purely spontaneous

hatred of the factories which they saw as prisons and the wamework which they still despised.

But the disturbances raised a real apprehension in the country. Ricardo almost alone among the respectable people admitted that perhaps machinery did not always operate to the immediate benefit of the workman, and for this opinion he was regarded as having slipped, for once, from his usual acumen. To most observers the sentiment was less reflective: the lower orders were getting out of hand and should be severely dealt with. And to the gentler classes, the situation seemed to indicate the coming of a violent and terrifying Armageddon. Southey, the poet, wrote: "At this moment nothing but the Army preserves us from that most dreadful of all calamities, an insurrection of the poor against the rich, and how long the Army may be depended upon is a question which I scarcely dare ask myself"; and Walter Scott lamented, ". . . the country is mined beneath our feet."

Little wonder that Malthus and Ricardo were such prophets of gloom and strife!

But all through this dark and troubled period, one spot in Britain shone like a beacon through the storm. In the dour mountains of Scotland, a good day's post from Glasgow, in country so primitive that the tollgate keepers at first refused gold coins (never having seen them before), stood the gaunt seven-story brick mills of a little community called New Lanark. Over the hilly roads from Glasgow rode a constant stream of visitors—twenty thousand signed the guestbook at New Lanark between 1759 and 1825—and the visiting crowds included such dignitaries as the Grand Duke Nicholas, later to be Tsar Nicholas I of Russia, Princes John and Maximilian of Austria, and a whole covey of parish deputations, writers, reformers, sentimental ladies, and skeptical businessmen.

What they came to see was the living proof that the squalor and depravity of industrial life were not the only and inevitable social arrangement. Here at New Lanark

were neat rows of workers' homes with every house; here were streets with the garbage neatly piled up awaiting disposal instead of being strewn in filthy disarray. And in the factories a still more unusual sight greeted the visitors' eyes. Over each employee hung a little cube of wood with a different color painted on each side: black, blue, yellow, and white. From darkest to lightest, the colors stood for different grades of deportment: white was excellent; yellow, good; blue, indifferent; black, bad. At a glance the factory manager could see how his work force was faring. It was mainly yellow and white.

two rooms in

For another surprise there were no children in the factories—at least none under the age of ten or eleven—and those that did work toiled only a short ten-and-three-quarter-hour day. Furthermore they were never punished; no one in fact was punished, and save for a few adult incorrigibles who had to be expelled for chronic drunkenness or some such vice, discipline seemed to be wielded by benignity rather than fear. The door of the factory manager stood open and anyone could (and did) present his objections to any rule or regulation. Everyone could inspect the book which contained the detailed report of his department and thus served as referent for the assignment of his colored cube, and he could appeal if he felt that he had been unjustly rated.

Most remarkable of all were the little children. Instead of running wild and fierce through the streets, the visitors found them in a large schoolhouse, fast at work and play. The littlest were learning the names of the rocks and trees they found about them; the slightly older were learning grammar from a frieze where General Noun contested with Colonel Adjective and Corporal Adverb. Nor was it all work, delightful as the work seemed to be. Regularly the children gathered to sing and dance under the tutelage of young ladies who had been instructed that no child's question was ever to go unanswered, that no child was ever bad without reason, that punishment was never to be inflicted, and that children would learn faster from the power of example than from admonition.

It must have been a wonderful and, indeed, an inspiring sight. And for the business-minded gentlemen
 10 were less likely to be carried away by the sight of happy children than the tenderhearted ladies, there was the irrefutable fact that New Lanark was profitable marvelously profitable. This was an establishment run
 a°thatly by a Saint but by an eminently practical one.

It was not only a practical saint who was responsible for New Lanark but a most improbable one. Like so many of the early nineteenth-century reformers on whom we look back as the Utopian Socialists, Robert Owen the “benevolent Mr. Owen of New Lanark,” was a strange mixture of practicality and naivete, achievement and fiasco, common sense and madness. Here was a man who advocated the abandonment of the plow in favor of the spade; a man who from scratch became a great capitalist and from a great capitalist a violent opponent of private property; a man who advocated benevolence because it would pay dividends, and who then urged the abolition of money.

It is hard to believe that one man's life could take so many twists. It began as a chapter straight from Horatio Alger. Born of poor parents in Wales in 1771, Robert Owen left school at the age of nine to become apprenticed to a linen draper with the unlikely name of McGuffog. He might have stayed a linen draper always and watched the store name change to McGuffog and Owen, but in true business-hero style, he chose to go to Manchester; and there, at the age of eighteen and on the strength of «£ 100 borrowed from his brother, he set himself up as a tiny capitalist manufacturing textile machinery. But the best was yet to come. A Mr. Drinkwater, the owner of a large spinning establishment, found himself one morning without a factory manager and advertised in the local paper for applicants. Owen had no knowledge of spinning mills, but he got the post in a fashion which might have provided a test for countless writers on the virtues of Pluck and Luck. “I put on my hat,” wrote

Owen over a half century later, “and proceeded straight to Mr. Drinkwater’s counting house. ‘How old are you. Twenty this May/’ was my reply. ‘How often do you get drunk in the week?’ ... ‘I was never/ I said drunk in my life/ blushing scarlet at this unexpected question. ‘What salary do you ask?’ ‘Three hundred a year, was my reply. ‘What?’ Mr. Drinkwater said, with some surprise, repeating the words, ‘Three hundred a year! I have had this morning I know not how many seeking the situation and I do not think all their askings together would amount to what you require/ ‘I cannot be governed by what others seek/ said I, ‘and I cannot take less.

It was a characteristic Owen gesture and it succeeded. At twenty he became the boy wonder of the textile world—an engaging young man with a rather straight nose in a very long face, and with large, frank eyes that advertised his candor. Within six months Mr. Drinkwater offered him a quarter interest in the business. But this was still only the prelude to a fabulous career. Within a few years Owen had heard of a set of mills for sale in the squalid village of New Lanark—coincidentally they were owned by a man with whose daughter he had fallen in love. To acquire either the mills or the hand of the daughter looked like an impossible feat: Mr. Dale, the millowner, was a fervid Presbyterian who would never approve of Owen’s radical free-thinking ideas, and then there was the question of how to find the capital to buy the mills. Nothing daunted, Owen marched up to Mr. Dale as he had once marched up to Mr. Drinkwater and the impossible became done. He borrowed the money, bought the mills, and won the hand of the daughter in the bargain.

Matters might well have rested there. Within a year Owen had made New Lanark a changed community; within five years it was unrecognizable; in ten years more it was world-famous. It would have been accomplishment enough for most men, for in addition to winning a European reputation for farsightedness and benevolence, Robert Owen made a fortune of at least £60,000 for himself.

But matters did not rest there. Despite his meteoric rise, Owen conceived of himself as a man of ideas rather than as a mere man of action; New Lanark had never been for him an idle exercise of philanthropy. Rather it was an opportunity to test out theories which he had evolved for the advancement of humanity as a whole. For Owen was convinced that mankind was no better than its environment and that if that environment were changed, a real paradise on earth might be achieved. In New Lanark he could, as it were, test his ideas in a laboratory, and since they succeeded beyond all measure there seemed no reason why they should not be given to the world.

He soon had his chance. The Napoleonic Wars subsided and in their wake came trouble. A succession of what Malthus would have called "general gluts" wracked the country; from 1816 to 1820 with the exception of a single year, business was very bad. The misery threatened to explode: "bread and blood" riots broke out and a kind of hysteria gripped the country. The Dukes of York and Kent and a body of notables formed a committee to look into the causes of the distress and purely as a matter of course they called upon Mr. Owen, the philanthropist, to present his views.

The committee was hardly prepared for what it got. It had no doubt expected a plea for factory reform, for Mr. Owen was widely known for his championship of a shorter working day and the abolition of child labor. Instead the notables found themselves reading a blueprint for social reorganization on a sweeping scale.

What Owen suggested was that the solution to the problem of poverty lay in making the poor productive. To this end he advocated the formation of Villages of Cooperation in which eight hundred to twelve hundred souls would work together in farm and factory to form a self-sustaining unit. The families were to live in houses grouped in parallelograms—the word immediately caught the public eye—with each family in a private apartment but sharing common sitting rooms and reading rooms and kitchens. Children over the age of three were to be

boarded separately so that they could be exposed to the kind of education which would best mold their characters for later life. Around the school were gardens to be tended by the slightly older children, and around them in turn would stretch out the fields where crops would be grown—needless to say with the aid of spades and without the use of plows. In the distance, away from the living areas, would be a factory unit; in effect this would be a planned garden city.

The committee of notables was considerably taken aback. It was hardly prepared to urge the adoption of planned social communities in a day of untrammelled *laissez faire*. Mr. Owen was thanked and Mr. Owen's ideas were carefully ignored. But Owen was nothing if not single-purposed. He insisted upon a review of the applicability of his plans and flooded Parliament with tracts expounding his views. Again his determination won the day. In 1819 a special committee (including David Ricardo) was put together for the purpose of trying to raise the necessary ninety-six thousand pounds to establish one full-fledged experimental Village of Cooperation.

Ricardo was skeptical although willing to give the plan a trial, but the country was not skeptical at all; it found the idea an abomination. One editorialist wrote: "Robert Owen, Esq., a benevolent cotton-spinner . . . conceives that all human beings are so many plants which have been out of the earth for a few thousand years, and require to be reset. He accordingly determines to dibble them in squares after a new fashion. . . . Everybody, I believe, is convinced of Mr. Owen's benevolence and that he proposes to do us much good. I ask him to let us alone, lest he do us much mischief." Another critic, William Cobbett, then in exile in America for his own radical ideas, was even more scornful. "This gentleman," he wrote, "is for establishing communities of paupers! . . . Wonderful peace, happiness, and national benefit are to be the result. How the little matters of black eyes, bloody noses, and pulling of caps are to be settled, I do not exactly see. Mr. Owen's scheme has, at any rate, the recommendation of perfect novelty, for of such a thing as

a community of paupers, I believe no human being has ever before heard. . . . Adieu, Mr. Owen of Lanark.”

Owen did not, of course, envision a community of paupers. He believed, on the contrary, that paupers could become the producers of great wealth if they were given a chance to work, and that their habits could be easily transformed into virtuous ones under the influence of a decent environment. And it was not only paupers who were to be thus elevated. The Villages of Cooperation were to be so manifestly superior to the turmoil of industrial life that other communities would naturally follow suit.

deplorable social

But it was obvious that Owen held his views alone. Serious-minded people saw in Owen’s scheme a disturbing threat to the established order of things, and radical-minded people saw in it only a farce. The necessary money for the trial Village was never raised, but now there was no stopping the indomitable philanthropist. He had been a humanist; now he became a professional humanitarian. He had made a fortune; now he dedicated it to the realization of his ideas. He sold his interest in New Lanark and in 1824 set about building his own community of the future. Not unnaturally he chose America for his milieu, for where better to build Utopia than in the midst of a people who had known political liberty for fifty years?

For a site he bought from a religious sect of Germans known as Rappites a tract of thirty thousand acres on the banks of the Wabash in Posey County, Indiana. On the Fourth of July, 1826, he dedicated it with a Declaration of Mental Independence—*independence from Private Property, Irrational Religion, and Marriage*—and then left it to shift for itself with its lovely wishful name of New Harmony.

It could not and did not succeed. Owen had envisioned a Utopia sprung full-blown into the world and he was not prepared to wean one from the imperfect environment of the old society. There was no planning: eight hundred settlers poured in, helter-skelter, within a few weeks. There was not even elementary precaution against

fraud. Owen was bilked by an associate who piled insult upon injury by setting up a whiskey distillery on land that he had unfairly taken. And since Owen was not there, rival communities sprang up: Macluria under one William McClure and others under other dissidents, the pull of acquisitive habit was too strong for the bond of ideas; in retrospect it is only astonishing that the community managed to exist for as long as it did.

By 1828 it was apparent that the enterprise was a failure. Owen sold the land (he had lost four-fifths of his entire fortune in the venture) and went off to talk about his schemes to President Jackson and then to Santa Ana in Mexico. Neither of these gentlemen expressed more than polite interest.

Owen now came back to England. He was still the benevolent (if slightly cracked) Mr. Owen, and his career was about to take its final unexpected twist. For while most opinion had mocked at his Villages of Cooperation, his teachings had sunk deep into one section of the country: the working classes. This was the time of the first modern trade-unions, and the leaders of the spinners and the potters and the builders had come to regard Owen as a man who could speak for their interests—indeed, as their leader. Unlike his peers, they took his teachings seriously—while the Villages of Cooperation were being debated by committees of notables, real working cooperative societies based on his tracts were springing up throughout the country on a more modest scale: producers' cooperatives and consumers' cooperatives and even a few ill-fated attempts to follow Mr. Owen's ideas to the letter and do away with money.

Without exception, the producers' cooperatives failed and the moneyless exchanges ended in moneyless but equally final bankruptcies. But one aspect of the cooperative movement took root. Twenty-eight devoted men who called themselves the Rochdale Pioneers began the consumer cooperative movement. To Owen it was only of passing interest, but with time it grew to be one of the great sources of strength of the Labour party in Great Britain. Curiously, the movement in which he took least

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interest was to survive all the projects into which he poured his heart and strength.

Owen had no time for cooperatives for a good reason—on his return from America he had conceived a humane moral crusade and he plunged into it with a typical vigorous abandon. The onetime poor boy, onetime capitalist, onetime social architect now drew around him the leaders of the working-class movement. He bestowed a properly impressive name on his project: the Grand National Moral Union of the Productive and Useful Classes. The name was soon shortened to the Grand National Consolidated Trades Union, and since that was still quite a mouthful, to the Grand National. Under its banner the trade-union leaders rallied, and in 1833 the English working-class movement was officially launched.

It was a nationwide union—the precursor of the industrial trade-unions of our day. Its membership was five hundred thousand—a mammoth figure for that time—and it embraced virtually every important union in all of England. But, unlike a modern union, its goals were not limited to hours and wages or even to management prerogatives. The Grand National was to be an instrument not only of social betterment but of social change. Hence while its program asked for better wages and working conditions, it went on to expound a fuzzy amalgam of Villages of Cooperation, the abolition of money, and a number of other ideas from the potpourri of Owen's writing.

Owen stumped the country for his final cause. It was a flat fiasco. England was no more prepared for a national trade-union than America for a local paradise. Local unions could not control their members and local strikes weakened the national body. Owen and his lieutenants fell out; they accused him of atheism, and he charged them with fomenting class hatred. The government stepped in and with violence and vengeance did its best to disrupt the growing movement. The employing classes heard in the Grand National the knell of private property and called for prosecution under antiunion laws. No youthful movement could have withstood such an on-

slaught. Within two years the great union was cieaa, a Owen at the age of sixty-four had played his last histon-

He continued for another twenty years, the grand old man of labor, urging his cooperative ideas, his preference for the spade, his naive distrust of money. In 1839 he had an audience with Queen Victoria despite the protests of a group of the best people known as the Society for Peaceably Repressing Infidelity. But he was finished. In his last years he found a refuge in spiritualism, in endless tracts endlessly the same, and in his wonderful Autobiography. In 1858, eighty-seven years old and still hopeful, he died.

What a romantic and fantastic story! And looking back, it is his story rather than his ideas which interests us. Owen was never a truly original and certainly never a flexible thinker. "Robert Owen is not a man to think differently of a book for having read it," was the devastating way in which one contemporary writer characterized him, and Macaulay, who fled at the sound of his voice, called him "always a gentle bore."

He was not, by any stretch of the imagination, an economist. But he was more than that: he was an economic innovator who reshaped the raw data with which economists have to deal. Like all the Utopian Socialists, Owen wanted the world changed; but while others wrote, powerfully or otherwise, he went ahead and tried to change it.

And on second thought, perhaps he did leave one great idea behind him. It is charmingly illustrated in this anecdote from the biography of his son, Robert Dale Owen.

"When the child screams from temper, my dear Caroline," said his father (Robert Owen), "set him in the middle of the nursery floor and be sure you don't take him up until he stops crying." "But my dear, he'll go on crying by the hour." "Then let him cry." "It may hurt his little lungs, and perhaps throw him into spasms." "I think not. At all events, it will hurt him more if he

grows into an ungovernable boy. Man is the creature of circumstances.”

“Man is the creature of circumstances” And who makes the circumstances but man himself? The world is not inevitably good or bad, but to the extent that we make it so. In that thought Owen left behind him a philosophy of hope more powerful than all of his fanciful notions about spades and plows or money or Villages of Cooperation.

Robert Owen is certainly the most romantic of that group of nineteenth-century protesters against raw capitalism, but he is by no means the most peculiar. For sheer perversity of character, honor must go to Count Claude Henri de Rouvroy de Saint-Simon and for indisputable eccentricity of ideas there is no peer of Charles Fourier.

Saint-Simon, as his rolling name suggests, was an aristocrat; his family claimed descent from Charlemagne. Born in 1760, he was brought up to be conscious of the nobility of his ancestry and of the importance of maintaining the luster of his name; every morning, as a youth, he was awakened by his valet who would cry: “Arise, Monsieur le Comte, you have great things to do today .”

The knowledge that one is a chosen vessel of history can do strange things to a man. In Saint-Simon’s case, it provided the excuse for an extravagant self-indulgence. Even as a boy he confused a devotion to principle with sheer pigheadedness; it is said that when a passing wagon interfered with a childhood game, he threw himself down across the road and obstinately refused to budge—and who was to throw a young count into the ditch? Later this same obstinacy led him to refuse to go to Communion at his father’s behest—but the father, perhaps more used to his son’s intransigence and certainly less awed by it, promptly threw him in jail.

His self-indulgence might have turned him toward that most self-indulgent of all political groups, the court of Louis XVI. But it was redeemed by a love for a most uncourtly idea: democracy. In 1778 the young count went to America and distinguished himself in the Rev-

olutionary War. He fought in five campaigns won the Order of Cincinnatus, and most important of all, became a passionate disciple of the new ideas of freedom and equality. . . ,

But this did not yet constitute Great Things. The Revolutionary War left him in Louisiana; thence he went to Mexico to urge the Viceroy to build a canal that would have preceded the Panama. That might have made his name, but the idea came to naught—it was, of course, nine-tenths idea and one-tenth plan—and the young revolutionary noble returned to France.

He was just in time for the Revolution there, and he threw himself into it with fervor. His townspeople of Falvy in Peronne asked him to be mayor and he refused, saying that the election of the old nobility would be a bad precedent; then when they chose him for the National Assembly anyway, he proposed the abolition of titles and renounced his own to become plain Citoyen Bonhomme. His democratic predilections were not a pose; Saint-Simon had a genuine feeling for his fellow man. Before the Revolution he had been posting to Versailles one day, in the height of style, when he came across a farmers cart mired in the road. Saint-Simon got down from his carriage, put his elegantly clad shoulder to the wheel, and then found the farmer's conversation so interesting that he dismissed his own vehicle and rode to Orleans with his new-found peasant friend.

The Revolution dealt strangely with him. On the one hand he speculated adroitly in Church lands and made himself a modest fortune; on the other he busied himself with a gigantic educational scheme which, because it threw him into contact with foreigners, brought him into disfavor and resulted in his being put in protective custody. He escaped and then, in a gesture both romantic and truly noble, surrendered himself again when he found that his hotel proprietor had been unjustly accused of collaborating in his escape.

This time he went to jail. But there, in his cell, there came to him the revelation for which he had, in a sense, been waiting all his life. The revelation came, as such

visitations do, in a dream; Saint-Simon described it thus:

“During the crudest period of the Revolution, and during a night of my imprisonment at Luxembourg, Charlemagne appeared to me and said: ‘Since the beginning of the world no family has enjoyed the honor of producing both a hero and philosopher of first rank. This honor was reserved for my house. My son, your successes as a philosopher will equal those which I achieved as a warrior and politician/’ ”

Saint-Simon asked for no more. He obtained a release from prison and the Aoney he had accumulated now poured forth in a fantastic search for knowledge. This man actually set out to know everything there was to know—scientists, economists, philosophers, politicians, all the savants of France were invited to his house, financed in their work, and endlessly queried that Saint-Simon might encompass the world’s intellectual scope. It was a bizarre endeavor. At one time, having come to the conclusion that he still lacked a firsthand acquaintance with family life for the pursuance of his social studies, he married—on a three-year contract. One year was enough: his wife talked too much and his guests drank too much, and Saint-Simon decided that marriage as an educational institution had its limitations. Instead he sought the hand of the most brilliant woman in Europe, Mme. de Stael; she was the only woman, he declared, who could understand his plans. They met, but it was an anticlimax; she found him full of esprit, but hardly the greatest philosopher in the world. In the circumstances, his enthusiasm also waned.

But the search for encyclopedic knowledge, while stimulating, was financially disastrous. His expenditures had been lavish to the point of recklessness; his marriage unexpectedly expensive. He found himself reduced first to modest circumstances and then to real poverty; he was forced to find a clerical job and then to depend on the kindness of an old servant for board and lodging. Meanwhile he was writing, furiously writing an endless stream of tracts, observations, exhortations, and examinations of

society. He sent his works to the leading patrons of the day with a pathetic note:

Monseieur:

Be my saviour, I am dying of hunger. ... For 15 days I have lived on bread and water . . . sold everything but my clothes, to pay for the expense of copies of my work. It is the passion for knowledge and the public welfare, the desire to find a peaceful means of ending the frightful crisis which engages all European society which has brought me to this state of distress. . . .

No one subscribed. In 1823, although his family now accorded him a small pension, he shot himself in despair. But he could never quite do anything as he wished. He only succeeded in losing an eye. He lived two more years, ill, impoverished, dedicated, and proud. When the end came, he gathered his few disciples around him and said, "Remember that in order to do great things one must be impassioned!"

But what had he done to justify such an operatic end?

A strange thing: he had founded an industrial religion. He had not done it through his books, which were voluminous enough but unread, nor through lectures, nor through doing "great things." Somehow the man himself had inspired a sect, had gathered a small band of followers, and had given society a new image of what it might be.

It was a strange, semimystical, and disorganized religion, and little wonder, for it was built on an unfinished and lopsided edifice of ideas. It was not even meant to be a religion as such—and yet after his death there was actually a Saint-Simonian Church with six departmental churches in France and with branches in Germany and England. Perhaps it is better compared to an order of brotherhood: his disciples dressed in shades of blue and ranked each other as "fathers and sons." And as a nice symbol of what the founder himself had stood for, they

wore a special waistcoat which could be neither put on nor taken off unassisted and which thus emphasized the dependence of every man on his brothers. But the church soon degenerated into little more than a cult, for the latter-day Saint-Simonians devised their own code of morality, which in some instances was little more than a respectably codified immorality.

The gospel which Saint-Simon had preached is hardly shocking to modern eyes. It proclaimed that "man must work if he is to share in society's fruits. But compared with the conclusions drawn from this premise, Robert Owen's society of parallelograms was clarity itself

"We suppose," writes Saint-Simon, "that France suddenly loses her fifty leading physicists, her fifty leading chemists, her fifty leading physiologists . . . mathematicians . . . mechanics and so on until three thousand savants, artists, and artisans have been accounted for (Saint-Simon is not noted for the economy of his style). What would be the result? It would be a catastrophe which would rob France of her very soul.

But now suppose, says Saint-Simon, that instead of losing these few individuals, France were to be deprived at one blow of its social upper crust: suppose it should lose M. the brother to the king, the Duke de Berry, some duchesses, the officers of the Crown, the ministers of state, its judges, and the ten thousand richest proprietors of the land—thirty thousand people in all. The result? Most regrettable, says Saint-Simon, because these are all good people, but the loss would be purely a sentimental one; the state would hardly suffer. Any number of people could discharge the functions of these lovely ornaments.

So the moral is clear. It is the workers—*les industriels*—of all ranks and hierarchies who merit the highest rewards of society and the idlers who deserve the least. But what do we find? By a strange miscarriage of justice, it is just the opposite: those who do the least get the most.

Saint-Simon proposes that the pyramid be set aright. Society is actually organized as a gigantic factory and it should carry out the factory principle to its logical con-

elusion. Government should be economic, not political: it should arrange things and not direct men. Rewards should be apportioned to one's social contribution: they should accrue to the active members of the factory and not to the lazy onlookers. It is not a revolution that Saint-Simon preaches nor even socialism as we understand the word. It is a kind of paean of the industrial process and a protest that in a society of toil, idlers should take such a lion's share of the wealth.

Not a word about how this is to be done: the later Saint-Simonians went a step beyond their founder and urged the end of private property, but even this left them with little more than a vague program of social 'reformation. This was a religion of work but it lacked a proper catechism; it pointed to grave injustices in the distribution of society's wealth, but it gave disappointingly little guidance to those who wanted to set things to rights.

Perhaps it was just this lack of a program which helped to account for the success of a man who was quite the opposite of Saint-Simon. For whereas the ex-nobleman had been inspired by a passion for the grand idea, Charles Fourier was inspired by a passion for trivia. Like Saint-Simon, Fourier believed the world was hopelessly disorganized, but the cure he proposed was explicit down to the tiniest detail.

Saint-Simon had been an adventurer in life; Fourier was an adventurer in imagination. His biography is largely a blank: born in 1772, the son of a tradesman of Besançon, he spent his days as an unsuccessful commercial traveler. In a sense he did nothing, not even marry. His passions were two: flowers and cats. It is only at the end of his life that he is appealing, for he spent his last years punctually sitting at advertised hours in his small room awaiting the visit of some great capitalist who would offer to finance his schemes to do over the world. After all, this little salesman had written, "I alone have confounded twenty centuries of political imbecility; and it is to me alone that present and future generations will

look for the origin of their immense happiness.” With such a responsibility resting on his shoulders, he could hardly afford not to be at hand when the appointed savior capitalist would arrive with his moneybags in train. But no one ever came.

Fourier, to be polite, was an eccentric; to be accurate he was probably mildly insane. His world was a fantasy: the earth, he believed, had been given a life of eighty thousand years; forty thousand of ascending vibrations and the same number of descending. In between (never mind the arithmetic) lay eight thousand years of the *Apogee du Bonheur*. We lived in the fifth of eight stages of advancement, having pushed through Confusion, Savagery, Patriarchism, and Barbarousness. Ahead lay Guaranteeism (not a bad bit of insight), and then the upward slope of Harmony. After we reached utter bliss, however, the seesaw would tip and we would work our way right back down through all the stages to the beginning.

But as we worked our way ever deeper into Harmony, things would really begin to pop: a Northern Crown would encircle the Pole shedding a gentle dew; the sea would become lemonade; six new moons would replace the old solitary satellite; and new species would emerge, better suited to Harmony: an anti-lion, a docile beast and most serviceable; an anti-whale, which could be harnessed to ships; an anti-bear; anti-bugs; and anti-rats. We would live to be one hundred and forty-four years old, of which one hundred and twenty years would be spent in the unrestricted pursuit of sexual love.

All this plus a firsthand description of the inhabitants of other planets gives to Fourier’s writings the air of a madman. Perhaps he was. But when he turned his starry vision to this earth he saw in it chaos and unhappiness and he saw, as well, a way to reorganize society.

His prescription was very exact. Society should be organized into phalanxes—the French word is *phalansteres*—which would consist of a kind of Grand Hotel arrangement, not too dissimilar from Owen’s Villages of Cooperation. The hotel was carefully described: there would be a large central building (its various rooms and their

dimensions were all thought out) and around it would be fields and industrial establishments. You could have in the hotel at the scale best suited to your purse; first, second, or third class, with just as much privacy as you desired (including meals in your rooms) and with just enough mingling to spread a leaven of culture. Efficiency would be achieved through centralization; Fourier, the old bachelor, paints a mouth-watering picture of the triumphs of the central cuisine.

Everyone would have to work, of course, for a few hours each day. But no one would shirk work, for each would do what he best liked. Thus the problem of dirty work was solved by asking who liked to do dirty work. The children, of course. So there would be Little Hordes who would go off gaily to the slaughter houses or to mend the roads and have the time of their lives. And for the minority of children who shrank from dirty work, there would be Little Bands who would tend the flowers and correct their parents' bad pronunciation. Between all workers there would be a game of competition to see who did best: contests of pear growers and cultivators of spinach and finally (once the phalanstery principle had encircled the globe and the 2,985,984 necessary phalansteres established) great battles of omelette chefs and champagne bottlers.

And the whole affair would be profitable in the extreme; gains would run to thirty per cent. But it would be communal profit: the surplus would be divided five-twelfths to labor, four-twelfths to capital, and three-twelfths to "ability," and everybody would be urged to become a part owner as well as a fellow worker.

Weird and fantastic as it seems, the Fourierist idea took some hold, even in that fortress of practicality and common sense, the United States. At one time there were over forty phalansteries in this country, and if one groups together the Owenite communities and the religious movements of various sorts, there were at least one hundred and seventy-eight actual Utopian groups with from fifteen to nine hundred members each.

Their variety was immense: some were pious, some

impious; some chaste, some licentious; some capitalistic, others anarchic. There were Trumbull Phalanx in Ohio and Modern Times on Long Island; there were Oneida and Brook Farm and New Icaria and one rather remarkable phalanx—the North American Phalanx in New Jersey—which endured from 1843 to 1855 and then lingered on, half hotel, half community, until the late 1930's. Of all unlikely people, Alexander Woollcott was born there.

None of the dream communities took solid root. Dream worlds have a difficult time contending with the frictions of reality, and of all the projected Utopian rearrangements of society, none was so far removed from practicality as the phalanstere. And yet, none is so beguiling. If we could live in a phalanstere, who would not like to? Fourier, gentle dreamer that he was, pointed with devastating truth to the miserable unhappiness of the world in which he lived, but his prescription was too much compounded of heavenly ingredients for the mortal ills he wished to cure.

Do they appear ridiculous, these Utopians? It is true that they were all dreamers—but as Anatole France has said, without dreamers, mankind would still live in caves. There was not one without a touch of madness: even Saint-Simon speculated solemnly on the possibility of the beaver, as the most intelligent animal, someday replacing humankind. But they are not noteworthy because they were eccentrics or because of the richness and appealing quality of their fantasies. They are worth our attention because they were courageous, and to appreciate that courage we must appraise and understand the intellectual climate in which they lived.

They lived in a world which was not only harsh and cruel but which rationalized its cruelty under the guise of economic law. Necker, the French financier and statesman, said at the turn of the century, "Were it possible to discover a kind of food less agreeable than bread but having double its sustenance, people would be reduced to eating only once in two days." And such a sentiment, hard though it might have sounded, did ring with a kind

of definitiveness. It was the world which was cruel, not the people in it. For the world was run by economic laws, and economic laws were nothing with which one could or should trifle: they were simply there and to lail about whatever injustices might be tossed up as an unfortunate consequence of their working was as foolish as to lament the ebb and flow of the tides.

The laws were few but final. We have seen how Adam Smith, Mai thus, and Ricardo elaborated the laws of economic distribution. These laws seemed to explain not only how the produce of society tended to be distributed but how it should be distributed. The laws showed that profits were evened out and controlled by competition, that wages were always under pressure from population, and that rent accrued to the landlord as society expanded. And that was that. One might not necessarily like the result, but it was apparent that this result was the natural outcome of society's dynamics: there was no personal ill-will involved nor any personal manipulation. Economic laws were like the laws of gravitation and it seemed as nonsensical to challenge one as the other. Hence an elementary economics textbook of the times said: "A hundred years ago only savants could fathom them [economic laws]. Today they are commonplaces of the nursery, and the only real difficulty is their too great simplicity."

No wonder the Utopians went to such extremes. The laws did look inviolable—and yet the state of society for which they were held responsible was intolerable. So the Utopians took their courage in both hands and said in effect, the whole system must change. If this is capitalism—with a nod of the head at Robert Blincoe chained to a machine let us have anything else—Villages of Cooperation, moral codes, or the delightful resort atmosphere of a phalanstere. The Utopians—and there were many besides those mentioned in this chapter—were reformers of the heart rather than the head. Their heritage is to be found in the welfare ideals of the New Deal of Britain or Scandinavia rather than in the "scientific" conviction of the Russian Soviets.

Note that they were Utopian Socialists. The "utopia"

was not merely a matter of idealistic ends; it was also a key to the means. For, in contradistinction to the Communists, these were reformers who hoped to persuade the members of the upper classes that social change would be for their own ultimate benefit. The Communists talked to the masses and urged violence, if necessary, to encompass their ends; the Socialists appealed to their own kind—to the intelligentsia, the petit bourgeois, the freethinking middle-class citizen or the intellectually emancipated aristocrat—for adherents to their schemes. Even Robert Owen hoped to get his brother millowners to see the light.

But secondly, note that these were Utopian Socialists. This meant they were economic reformers. Utopia-builders had existed since Plato but it was not until the French Revolution that they began to react to economic as well as political injustice. And since it was early capitalism which provided the chamber of horrors against which they revolted, not unnaturally they turned their backs on private property and the struggle for private wealth. Few of them thought of reform within the system: remember that this was the age of the very first watered-down factory legislation and that such grudging reforms as were painfully won were largely honored in the breach. The Utopians wanted something better than reform—they wanted a new society in which Love Thy Neighbor could somehow be made to take priority over the mean gouging of each for himself. In the communality of property, in the warmth of common ownership, was to be found the touchstone of human progress.

They were men of very good will. And yet, for all their good intentions and their earnest theories, the Utopians lacked the stamp of respectability; they needed the imprimatur of someone with them in heart but whose head would be somewhat more firmly attached to his shoulders. And they found such a person in the most unlikely place—in the ultimate conversion to Socialism of the greatest—by common consent the greatest—economist of the age: John Stuart Mill.

Everyone in this chapter is a somewhat unbelievable character but perhaps J. S. Mill is the most remarkable of them all. His father was James Mill, historian, philosopher, pamphleteer, friend and intimate of Ricardo and Jeremy Bentham, one of the leading intellects of the early nineteenth century. James Mill had definite ideas about almost everything, and especially about education. His son, John Stuart Mill, was the extraordinary result.

John Stuart Mill was born in 1806. In 1809 (not 1819) he began to learn Greek. At age seven he had read most of the dialogues of Plato. The next year he began Latin, having meanwhile digested Herodotus, Xenophon, Diogenes Laertius, and part of Lucian. Between eight and twelve, he finished Virgil, Horace, Livy, Sallust, Ovid, Terence, Lucretius, Aristotle, Socrates, and Aristophanes; had mastered geometry, algebra, and the differential calculus; written a Roman History, an Abridgment of the Ancient Universal History, a History of Holland, and a few verses. "I never composed at all in Greek, even in prose, and but little in Latin," he wrote in his famous Autobiography. "Not that my father could be indifferent to the value of this practice . . . but because there really was not the time for it."

At the ripe age of twelve, Mill took up logic and the work of Hobbes. At thirteen he made a complete survey of all there was to be known in the field of political economy.

It was a strange, and by our standards a dreadful, upbringing. There were no holidays, "lest the habit of work should be broken, and a taste for idleness acquired," no boyhood friends, and not even a real awareness that his education and rearing were significantly different from the normal. The miracle is not that Mill subsequently produced great works, but that he managed to avoid a complete destruction of his personality. He did have a kind of nervous breakdown: in his twenties, the delicate dry intellectual world of work and effort on which he had been nourished suddenly became sterile and unsatisfying, and while other youths had to discover that there could be beauty in intellectual activity, poor Mill had to

find that there could be beauty in beauty. He underwent a siege of melancholy; then he read Goethe, then Wordsworth, then Saint-Simon—all people who spoke of the heart as seriously as his father had spoken of the brain. And then he met Harriet Taylor.

There was, worse luck, a Mr. Taylor. He was ignored—Harriet Taylor and Mill fell in love and for twenty years wrote each other, traveled together, and even lived together—all (if we are to believe their correspondence) in perfect innocence. Then the barrier of Mr. Taylor was removed by his death and the two finally married.

It was a superlative match. Harriet Taylor (and her belated daughter, Helen) completed for Mill the emotional awakening which had begun so late; together, the two women opened his eyes to women's rights and, even more importantly, to mankind's right. After Harriet's death, when he was reflecting on the story of his life, he reviewed their converging influences on himself, and he wrote: "Who, either now, or hereafter, may think of me and of the work I have done, must never forget that it is the product not of one intellect and conscience, but of three."

Mill, as we have seen, learned all the political economy there was to know at the age of thirteen. It was not until thirty years later that he wrote his great text, the two long, masterfully written volumes of the Principles of Political Economy. It was as if he had accumulated thirty years of knowledge just for this purpose.

The book is a total survey of the field: it takes up rent and wages and prices and taxes and retreads the paths that had been first mapped by Smith and Malthus and Ricardo. But it is far more than a mere updating of doctrines that had by now received the stamp of virtual dogma. It goes on to make a discovery of its own, a discovery of monumental importance. For Mill brings to light a principle which forever after rescues economics from the category of a dismal science.

The discovery, like so many great insights, was very simple. It consisted in pointing out that the true province of economic law was production and not distribution.

What he meant was very clear: the economic laws of production concern nature. There is nothing arbitrary about whether labor is more productive in this use or that, nor is there anything capricious or optional about such economic phenomena as the diminishing powers of productivity of the soil. Scarcity and the obduracy of nature are real things and the economic rules of behavior which tell us how to maximize the fruits of our labor are as impersonal and as absolute as the laws of the expansion of gases or the interaction of chemical substances.

But—and this is perhaps the biggest but in economics—the laws of economics have nothing to do with distribution. Once we have produced wealth as best we can, we can do with it as we like. "The things are there/' says Mill; "mankind, individually or collectively, can do with them as they please. They can place them at the disposal of whomsoever they please, and on whatever terms. . . . Even what a person has produced by his individual toil, unaided by anyone, he cannot keep, unless by the permission of society. Not only can society take it from him, but individuals could and would take it from him, if society . . . did not . . . employ and pay people for the purpose of preventing him from being disturbed in [his] possession. The distribution of wealth, therefore, depends on the laws and customs of society. The rules by which it is determined are what the opinions and feelings of the ruling portion of the community make them, and are very different in different ages and countries, and might be still more different, if mankind so chose. .. /'

It was a body blow to the followers of Ricardo who had rigidified his objective findings into a strait jacket for society. For what Mill said was transparently obvious—once it had been said. Never mind if the "natural" action of society was to depress wages or to equalize profits or to raise rents or whatever. If society did not like the natural results of its activities, it had only to change them. Society could tax and subsidize, it could expropriate and redistribute. It could give all its wealth to a king, or it could run a gigantic charity ward; it could give due

heed to incentives, or it could—at its own risk—ignore them. But whatever it did, there was no “correct” distribution—at least none that economics had any claim to fathom. There was no appeal to “laws” to justify how society shared its fruits: there were only men sharing their wealth as they saw fit.

It was a discovery of profound consequence. For it lifted the whole economic debate from the stifling realm of impersonal and inevitable law and brought it back into the arena of ethics and morality. After Mill, economists might argue that men deserved such and such remuneration for this and that reason, but they could never again pretend that some abstract arithmetical force decreed that this was the way it should be done.

The discovery did not make Mill a Socialist in quite the sense of his Utopian brethren. Simply because society could reorder its distribution as it saw fit did not mean that it should upset the applecart. Mill believed that the world could advance within its given structural framework and he put little faith in a wholesale reorganization of the state.

“I confess,” he wrote, “I am not charmed with an ideal of life held out by those who think that the normal state of human beings is that of struggling to get on; that the trampling, crushing, elbowing, and treading on each other’s heels, which form the existing type of social life, are the most desirable lot of human kind, or anything but the disagreeable symptoms of one of the phases of industrial progress.”

But a distaste of acquisitiveness did not blind him to its usefulness. “That the energies of mankind should be kept in employment by the struggle for riches as they were formerly by the struggle for war, until the better minds succeed in educating the others into better things, is undoubtedly better than that they should rust and stagnate. While minds are coarse they require coarse stimuli and let them have them.”

It was a philosophy of resignation—and hope. Mill was a supreme believer in the ability of men to control their fate through reason. He believed that the working classes

would come to see the Malthusian specter and that they would thereupon gladly and voluntarily regulate their numbers. And if this hurdle was passed the rest would be easy. For Mills recognition that distribution obeyed no laws but human ones allowed him to see the world as capable of progress. Eventually the world would reach a stationary level: profits would have disappeared and there would be no more growth, but within the existing framework of society, improvements could still be made. The state would prevent the landlord from reaping an unearned benefit and it would tax away inheritances; men would turn from the struggle for gain to the pursuit of arts and life itself.

It would not be thoroughgoing socialism. While Mill recognized that property had its abuses, he saw as well that the property system was still in its infancy and capable of refinement; the abuses need not be inseparable from the institution. And then, in the system called communism, he saw a danger. For despite its claimed superiority on economic grounds, Mill sensed in it a non-economic but supremely important threat, and he set down his misgivings in these farsighted words:

... It is not by comparison with the present bad state of society that the claims of Communism can be estimated. . . . The question is, whether there would be any asylum left for individuality of character; whether public opinion would not be a tyrannical yoke; whether the absolute dependence of each on all, and the surveillance of each by all, would not grind all down into a tame uniformity of thoughts, feelings, and actions. . . . No society in which eccentricity is a matter of reproach can be in a wholesome state.

Mill lived until 1873, a venerated, almost worshiped man. His mildly Socialist leanings were forgiven in exchange for his vista of hope and his removal of the pall of despair. After all, what he advocated was not so shocking but that it could be embraced by almost everybody: taxation of rents, and inheritance taxes, and the formation

of workmens cooperatives. He was not very sanguine about the possibilities of trade-unions, and that was all to the good, as far as respectable opinion went. It was a doctrine English to the core: gradualist, optimistic, realistic, and devoid of radical overtones.

Principles of Political Economy was an enormous success. It went into seven editions in the expensive two-volume edition during his own lifetime and, characteristic of Mill, he had it printed at his own expense in one cheap volume which would be within the reach of the working class. Five cheap editions also sold out before he died. Mill became the Great Economist of his day; he was talked of as Ricardo's rightful successor and heir, and compared not unfavorably with Adam Smith himself.

And economics aside, the man himself was so respected. Mill was the author of *Logic*, of *Liberty*, of *Considerations on Representative Government*, and of *Utilitarianism*, all classics in their fields. And more than merely brilliant, he verged on being saintly. When Herbert Spencer, his great rival in the area of philosophy, found himself so straitened in circumstances that he was unable to complete his projected series on social evolution, it was Mill who offered to finance the project. "I beg that you will not consider this proposal in the light of a personal favor," he wrote his rival, "though even if it were I should still hope to be permitted to offer it. But it is nothing of the kind—it is a simple proposal of cooperation for an important public purpose, for which you give your labor and have given your health.

There was never a more typical gesture. Mill cared only for two things: his wife, for whom he conceived a devotion which his friends thought verged on blindness, and the pursuit of knowledge, from which nothing could deflect him. When he was elected to Parliament his defense of human rights exceeded the temper of the day; he was thereupon defeated, but he cared not a whit either way. As he saw the world, so he wrote and spoke, and the only person who mattered, as far as approval went, was his beloved Harriet.

After she died, there was her daughter, Helen, now

equally indispensable. In gratitude, Mill wrote in his *Autobiography*: “Surely no one before was so fortunate

lottery of life.” He retired to spend his last days with Helen in Avignon, near Harriet’s grave, a wonderfully wise and thoroughly great man.

One last coincidence. His masterwork on economics, with its message of progress and the opportunity for peaceful change and betterment, was published in 1848. Perhaps it was not an epoch-making book, but it was certainly an epoch-marking one. For by a curious quirk of fate another far smaller book—a pamphlet—was published in the same year. It was entitled *The Communist Manifesto* and in its few pages it undid, in bitter words, all the calm and buoyant reasonableness with which J. S. Mill had endowed the world.